India became independent from Britain in the context of the Cold War and, as described in Chapter 2: 1947–1971, had to immediately deal with questions of territoriality and development. India's attempts at incorporating the princely states (as well as French and Portuguese possessions) and creating buffer zones required both diplomacy and the use of military force. India also made efforts to manage its economy through state planning in the 1940s and 1950s. By being Non-Aligned, it attempted to benefit from economic and technical assistance from both the United States and the Soviet Union, along with their allies. The post-Independence period also saw India initiate its nuclear programme and attempt to position itself as a leader in the post-colonial world, including at the Bandung conference in 1955. But these developments were overtaken by growing tensions with China after its annexation of Tibet in 1950 and intensifying disputes along the contested border, culminating in a short but decisive border war in 1962. India's defeat in part contributed to Pakistan's adventurism and another war in 1965 which, while inconclusive, significantly altered dynamics in the Indian subcontinent. The period between 1965 and 1971 was marked by political and economic transitions, including a skirmish with China and the Green Revolution.

Chapter 3: 1971–1991 describes the last two decades of the Cold War. During this period, India aligned more closely with the Soviet Union out of concern for the US–China–Pakistan partnership. The victory over Pakistan in the Bangladesh Liberation War in 1971 proved decisive and defined relations between the two countries for decades. India conducted a peaceful nuclear explosion in 1974, but despite its success, India's nuclear weapons programme stalled until the early 1980s, when it began to revive following Pakistan's nuclear progress. This period was also marked by a slow and tentative re-engagement with China until 1985, when Beijing reasserted its claims. After India's response to a military stand-off in the late 1980s, a visit by Rajiv Gandhi to China began to normalize ties with Beijing. The latter years of the Cold War also witnessed Indian military and political interventions in its immediate region, including in Sri Lanka and the Indian Ocean. But a lasting legacy was India's continued economic isolationism at